nefarious opulence

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

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by orphan_account

Summary

Etheria, a modern world where three areas existed: the southern area, the neutral zone, and the northern one.

Adora and Catra had been born and raised in the gloomy streets of the neutral zone. But at 13 and 12 both are pulled to entirely different worlds. One went to the south while the other to the north. And now both must survive the new lives they got plunged into.

The neutral zone was a hideous place, Light Spinner concluded after half an hour of prowling its alleyways.

The air was so polluted from the deficient factories one could stand on one sidewalk and they wouldn't see the person on the opposite side. Most of the buildings were either rusty or had already crumpled; very few were standing upright. But the people were the worst of them all, no sorcerers or possessors only humans and hybrids, and ones who were already a good match to this decaying place.

If she had her way, she would have never set foot in this ghastly area. If she hadn't been refused, if she hadn't been humiliatingly banished from her own coven, she would have surpassed her limits, would have achieved the impossible. But authority in the hands of the small-minded was a saddening situation.

But enough moping and sullying, Light Spinner willed her thoughts away from those traitors. Now she's pursuing something extraordinary. Something no sorcerer has ever imagined to accomplish, for only the possessors drew power from the stones.

The possessors, or, considering that those powers only existed in the martial line and that the full term was possessors of runic and natural stones: PRNCs and that they have the most luxurious accommodations in practically everything, many youths chose to call them the princesses. A silly name if one was to ask her, utterly disregarding what great power those princesses have, the power to unleash hell upon anyone if they wished to do so.

Most stones were scattered behind the rebellion borders, and are already utilised.
But not this one, she had known so before she had been banished but only now did it ever occurred to her to actually use it.

She had procrastinated the search in various motels long enough. Tonight she would find it… and she did.

Although they were called stones, the only way to actually find them was to sense the aura they made. None knew where they were exactly, but most believed they had been buried hundreds of meters underground, Just like any rock, dormant until they sensed their possessors and beckoned them to sense their Users.

And so Light Spinner arched her head and gazed at the place where the stone dwelled, the last building she had ever imagined to find the stone in: an orphanage.

***

It has been more than half a decade since Light Spinner, or as she answered the bull-hybrid female who had asked her name 'Shadow Weaver', started working at the orphanage.

The first time she entered it she only intended to find where the aura of the stone resided the most. But after she did find it –in a discarded room– she didn't know what to do next, willing the stone to obey her would take months or even years, especially since it was so persistent to disobey her. And for that to happen they have to be physically close to each other. Another thing that served to show the difference between her and the possessors, who could use the power their stones granted even if they were a planet apart.

At first, she considered killing all of them— the children and the workers, and she would have done so if there hadn't been a tremendous number of them enough for someone to notice the disappearance even in a place like the neutral zone, so the only option she saw was to work here.

Which wasn't as unpleasant as she had expected: everyone obeyed her every command, just as a sorcerer was to be treated by those inferior to them. And this way she had already found a place to stay and a salary to spend.

As for the children, she never cared about them in particular. They were cared for, in her opinion, quite enough. They had their

clothes, their meals, their beds ready, most of them. They went to their rotten school in their rotten neighbourhood to learn the basic alphabet and numbers. They knew how to act properly when she was present, and in her view, that was perfect for them as it was.

Until one day she sensed a tremendous power like no other in the building, more powerful than the stone she used, power like shattering mountains and stopping sea waves, and of course she followed it. Only to find a human man she had seen numerous times, she must have imagined it, she told herself and was about to go upstairs if she hadn't noticed the bundle in his arms, she ordered him to give her it, and just as it touched her skin she knew why.

A babe with a blonde strand and blue eyes gazed up at her. And Shadow Weaver knew that this kid would be able to rule worlds if she wanted to and people would follow her either as minions or slaves. And just like any power-hungry person, she took her under her wing. and had named her Adora for she was to be adored by all and no matter what.

***

Adora was a loud thing, child and adult complained alike. She talked too loudly, they said, was too competitive, too bossy, too much.

And she never got in trouble for any of this, they said the most. And it was true no one would go against the scary magical lady to complain about her 'too much' unofficial daughter. And so as expected she never had friends, other children were either annoyed, scared, or jealous of her.

Which shadow weaver saw as no problem. If this girl was to climb to the top, it would be better if none were on her back to drag her down. Friends and relationships were all insignificant and a nuisance to successful people.

And she would have shared the same ideology if 3-year-old Adora hadn’t appeared one day with a cat-hybrid in her arms. Declaring that she had found her in a box, screaming “MINE!” and hitting anyone who tried to pry her from her arms even if she was swaying, the child in her arms didn't look very heavy, but then again, Adora wasn’t accustomed to carrying other children. Even Shadow Weaver, whom she followed every command, couldn't stop her from taking the younger female to her room.

She hadn’t cared much about it at that time. All children get bored of their toys after a while, and this will be no different, even if Adora had given the child hybrid a bed and a name (Catra: for Adora wanted everyone to know she was hers and mashed her last syllable ra with the child species, cat) and growled at anyone who got too close to her, give it a week or a two and Adora will get tired from that hybrid and leave her to be someone else’s problem.

Shadow Weaver hadn’t expected a life-long bond to blossom between the two.

***

For 11 years, it has always been Adora and Catra.

Catra and Adora.

Inseparable as wrapped rose vines.

And they only emphasised the point by sharing practically everything: the same bed. The same meals. Sitting together at the school classes and the orphanage halls. people would always see the two of them walking together, Adora would always have her arm wrapped between Catra’s arms, one around her bicep and the other her forearm. Anyone who pulls Catra’s tail would get a black eye. And any who made fun of Adora being the big girl who talked too loudly would get sent to the infirmary.

While both were very protective of each other, they were also very territorial and possessive. The first time Catra came to the

orphanage, a lot of kids were intrigued. because they had never seen anything like her and a new kid is always a delight for a group of emotionally neglected kids, but Adora, apparently, doesn’t share. Anyone who gets close enough in her opinion would be driven off by verbal cruelty, and if necessary physical violence. And the fight between Catra and Lonnie (who wanted to sit next to Adora in one of the school classes) was a story imprinted in everyone’s mind.

Depending on one’s perspective, one might think it was sort of unhealthy or might think it’s endearing for two people to be so engrossed with each other. But Adora and Catra never cared.

Late at night, when Adora had her chin on top of Catra's head, arms around each other and legs tangling, she would whisper that she would never leave Catra and would always protect her and Catra would say the same to Adora and always after that before they would let sleep claim them, everything in the world was right.

***

On one of the chilly days of autumn, Adora and Catra swung their joined hands as they headed toward the playground with a crowd of laughing, giggling children following them. Shadow Weaver had said that 13 and 12-year-olds were too big to play with other kids, they would merely escort them and make sure no one would kill themselves out of stupidity, and Adora and Catra, who never miss the chance to leave the orphanage’s gloomy cracked walls agreed.

After they settled the younger children, they decided to explore the area, until they realised they were nothing to explore but alleys and rusty scaffolding, they got bored and opted to just walk around.

After a few minutes of silly jokes, silly stories, and some gossip between the two, Adora's eyes caught something at the corner of the alleyway they were walking through. She picked it up and Catra –her hand still clasping Adora’s– leaned in to inspect it too.

It was a small, index-sized figurine, shaped like… a sword. They looked at each other, brows furrowed, and then shrugged. It wasn't the strangest thing they had ever seen before.

But it was a beautiful thing, it had golden-coloured hilt (for of course it was coloured no one would leave a mass of pure gold discarded in some alley) with a light blue dot in the centre of it. So Adora pocketed it in her yellow parkas. And went back to the playground to call back the kids.

They were supposed to get back with them but Adora, still full of energy, and Catra, never a fan of the orphanage, decided to stick a little longer, at least until the sunset.

***

Under the starry sky, laughing with each other, Adora and Catra lost track of time. And Adora was just about to tell Catra they should go back when they rounded a corner and saw a group of men beating a helpless hybrid.

Adora was quick to react, she grabbed Catra's hand and made to sprint but the loud gasp Catra let out alerted them and they took off towards them.

They only managed to get out of an alley when one of the bigger men grabbed Adora and slammed her against the wall while the others started advancing towards Catra and when she heard Catra's watery sob, Adora lost it.

If anyone asked her what happened, she didn't remember. She didn't remember knocking all the other men that surrounded them, she didn't remember looking down— yes, down at the man who was gripping Catra's arm, she didn't remember swinging a sword against him, she didn't remember the scream he let out, she didn't remember picking Catra up in one arm, she only remembered her worried face and her small helpless, "…Adora?", she didn't remember the darkness that Engulfed her.

***

The orphanage doesn’t have many visitors, nevertheless rich, powerful ones like Angella Brightmoon. Although the kids didn’t know her by her name, they knew her by her wings. One of the features that indicated how different possessors were, and at her hip was a pink-haired, frowning girl. Another possessor judging from the sparkles in her hair and eyes.

This woman had led the land at their south to prosperously like no other. All were familiar with her cold beautiful face, her soft but firm voice. All knew how kind she was to her population and how cruel but just she was to those who crossed her.

But most knew her as the leader of the organisation she established: the rebellion. At first, it was only possessors who were allowed to join but then more and more volunteered and now it formed a force that stretched all around her land and sometimes reached in the neutral zone streets.

And now she stood, demanding to speak with the manager here. Which Shadow Weaver took as to be her own summoning. Both ladies stood tall and firm and regarded each other with battle-like calculation.

At least that's what the kids saw before both of them disappeared behind the door of Shadow Weaver’s office.

Many children had their ears pressed to the door. But even if Adora and Catra wanted to know what they talked about, years of exceptional punishments only they had endured taught them not to do so. Shadow weaver appreciated her privacy very highly. So they just stood with the crowd of other, smarter kids. A reasonable distance from the door.

after what happened in the alleyways, Adora and Catra decided to stay away from trouble as much as possible, they hadn’t told anyone what happened, partly because they themselves didn’t what happened and was scared if anyone else understood it and wouldn’t tell them and partly because no one would probably believe that Adora turned into a giant woman with a glowing

sword and glowing eyes and fought a bunch of men with no scratch or at least that was what Catra described to Adora when she woke up, screaming for Catra habitually.

Suddenly, yelling arose from behind the door. Obviously, the two ladies must be just arguing but Adora and Catra didn't want to meet shadow weaver when she was this angry and went upstairs to the dorm they shared with three other kids: Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio.

Minutes flew by when they heard crashing sounds and more screaming. This one was different from the previous one, which was ignited by anger, this one was ignited by fear and the voices unmistakably belonged to children. Adora willed Catra to stay with the other three at the dorm as she went downstairs to check the situation.
And was dumbfounded.

Up near the high ceiling, Angella flew, using her wings to stay airborne, and defended herself with light beams against Shadow Weaver's merciless attacks. Both were screaming nonsense and Adora could only make out Angella shouting, "stop it, you're destroying your own orphanage." And Shadow Weaver replied with anger Adora had never witnessed before, "I don't care. YOU WILL NOT TAKE HER AWAY FROM ME!" Angella was right. Whenever Shadow Weaver launched a blast and it missed, it would hit one of the walls or the columns holding up the orphanage. And with a jolt, Adora realised the building was shaking.

She was about to go warn the others or maybe just take Catra and get out until things calmed down when a tan hand gripped her upper arm. She looked over to see the girl that accompanied Angella, where did she come from? There was none near Adora at that moment. The girl was obviously saying something but Adora, in her panic, couldn't decipher what the girl was even saying. She wanted to shake her off but the girl held firm.

Adora turned around to see Catra at the threshold of their dorm, her face confused and slightly scared asking Adora with her eyes, what's going on? But before she could answer the girl tugged her harder, Adora whirled her head and was about to scream at her to let her go when the girl beat her to it, "mom, says we have to go now!" And the world exploded to glimmers and sparkles.

***

More visitors arrived at the orphanage after that day, all asking for the same thing: the She-Ra. Which the kids understood after many attempts to mean Adora, who abandoned her friends and left the very day before all those weird people started appearing. But They were all refused from entering; Most say that Shadow Weaver wasn't doing very well at the moment.

But when an extremely important figure appears they didn't have that much of a choice but to let him in.

Horde Prime's fame was equal to Angella's Brightmoon. He, on the other hand, was the official leader of the land at their north. Which was significantly smaller than Angela's and the population was far less. But their technology was extremely developed and the organisation he created was the reason for the rebellion, for Angella feared the horde's power and wanted to protect her land no matter what.
But where the rebellion was semi-democratic the horde was a full-on theocracy. Every agent would do as he or she is told, no questioning of orders, no suggestions, no retirement. Some would think it was a cruel way to govern but Prime sees it as the best way to keep the systems from dismantling.

And so of course a face that represented all those things would ring fear in the heart of kids.

And since Shadow Weaver was shut in her room and refused to meet anyone. one of the eldest and bravest kids had to speak up and greet Prime. He just gazed at them and apparently seeing no other alternative asked where the She-Ra is. And this was the

hard part, who would be brave enough to tell the man who broke the necks of those who refused to lick his shoes clean that his prize had been taken, that he came here for nothing. Thankfully, he took their silence for an answer enough, and then… nodded. Most of the kids were confused and looked at each other in question, he even looked as if he expected it. And then asked, "Then, who was the closest to the She-Ra?"

If they were confused before they became perplexed now. None of the other visitors after Angella acted like this. They all demanded where She-Ra— Adora was and left in anger when they discovered her departure. But after a few moments of understanding the question, more than one face turned to look at Catra.

She had only went downstairs today because she already knew who he was, in any other case she had been like Shadow Weaver: shut in her room, bawling her eyes out, wallowing in self-pity. She started thinking that maybe Shadow Weaver was wise to stay upstairs.

But it was too late now, she just nodded at the unspoken question, trying so hard not to meet his eyes. She willed her heartbeat to slow down a bit and took a deep breath to answer him when he asked her name. "Catra,…sir." She hoped her voice was firm enough. He just looked at her more closely and after a few seconds of silence announced, "I had come here in little hope of finding the She-Ra and as expected she had already been claimed. And now I seek who knows her the best, who knows all her secrets." And then he gave the most gruesome imitation of a smile and asked, "would you come with me, child? Would you join me?"

Somewhere in the back of Catra's mind, a small voice said, I'm getting adopted. And another voice said really? But another replied say yes, you idiot. This isn't an opportunity that comes twice but yet another voice said don't you think it's kind of shady? This is Horde Prime we're talking about remember? But as different parts of her fought against each other. She already knew

it wasn’t an actual choice, Prime didn’t come hoping like some idealist, he already planned all of this, and if Catra didn’t agree… she didn’t want to finish that thought.

Well, then, two can play at the game.

She lifted her chin, straightened her back, looked Prime in the eye, and willed her voice to be the perfect mixture of firmness and nonchalant. “Yes, I’d like that.”

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